

MANDAR DEODHAR

STRAINS IN THE MVA File picture of Rahul Gandhi, NCP (SP) patriarch Sharad Pawar and Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray

MVA ALLY SHIV SENA (UBT) WAS SCATHING IN ITS COMMENTS, CALLING OUT THE CONGRESS FOR TURNING "A WINNING INNINGS INTO A DEFEAT"

other influential figures like Dalit leader and ex-Union minister Kumari Selja and senior leader Randeep S. Surjewala. In fact, Selja withdrew from active campaigning for 10 crucial days reportedly because she was miffed at Hooda's coterie cornering a bulk of the tickets.

Factionalism is hardly new to the Congress. Similar power struggles weakened the party in Chhattisgarh, MP and Rajasthan, where state-level leaders such as Bhupesh Baghel, Kamal Nath and Ashok Gehlot concentrated power, alienating the other factions. This lack of unity drained the Congress's campaigns of energy and opened the door for the BJP to exploit the party's weaknesses.

To avoid a repeat, the Congress must address internal discord and ensure that poll campaigns are not driven by the ambitions of a single leader. A more collective approach, as seen in Karnataka, where the party managed to balance the influence of Siddaramaiah and D.K. Shivakumar, could be a good model to follow. The 2023 win in Telangana also throws up a few pointers—the party did not overtly rely on any of the veteran leaders, which allowed it to fight as a cohesive unit, guided by the strategy drawn up by professional consultants.

RETHINK, REORGANISE

The Congress also needs to rethink its overall poll strategy. The party has moved away from its traditional role as an inclusive political umbrella, becoming narrowly focused on single-issue campaigns. In Haryana, for instance, the campaign revolved almost entirely around Jat leader Hooda, alienating the non-Jat communities like the Dalits, who felt sidelined. The result: Congress underperformed with non-Jat voters and failed to build the broad coalition necessary for victory. This also explains why despite an almost equal vote share (39.1 per cent to the BJP's 39.9 percent), it lost so many seats.

Moreover, the Congress's single-minded focus on a caste census, while appealing to the OBC communities, risks alienating Dalits and other marginalised groups who fear that such a census might dilute their existing reservations. In Haryana, the Congress ceded eight out of the 17 SC-reserved seats to the BJP, demonstrating its failure to establish itself as the party of choice for Dalit voters. The Congress's once-potent national narrative—such as the call to protect the Constitution—has also lost much of its appeal, especially after the BJP paid the price in the Lok Sabha election, with its tally reduced to 240 seats.

Besides, the party continues to struggle in urban areas, where it has consistently failed to connect with voters. In Haryana, the BJP won 18 of the 25 urban seats, while Congress managed just five. This poses an even larger challenge in Maharashtra, where nearly 45 per cent of the population lives in urban areas.

Perhaps the Congress's most glaring weakness is its floundering grassroots machinery. In Haryana, poor booth-level coordination cost the party several close races (nine seats by less than 6,000 votes). Indeed, even in the LS poll, it had won five seats by razor-thin margins. "Instead of working on improving the margins, the party assumed success. The leadership must not repeat the same mistakes in Maharashtra and Jharkhand," says a Congress Rajya Sabha MP. Micro-level constituency management has to be the focus, adds an AICC general secretary. Add to that internal fractures, organisational inefficiencies and alliance frictions. The party has a lot to do before it can reclaim its standing as a national force capable of going toe to toe with the BJP. ■